

IT IS TIME TO TAKE THE PLUNGE

TEXT: Mark 1:9-11 (NKJV) *“It came to pass in those days that Jesus came from Nazareth of Galilee, and was baptized by John in the Jordan. ¹⁰And immediately, coming up from the water, He saw the heavens parting and the Spirit descending upon Him like a dove. ¹¹Then a voice came from heaven, “You are My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased.”*

Mark 16:15-16 (NKJV) *“He said to them, “Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature. ¹⁶“He who believes and is baptized will be saved; but he who does not believe will be condemned.”*

Colossians 2:12 (NKJV) *“Buried with Him in baptism, in which you also were raised with Him through faith in the working of God, who raised Him from the dead.”*

INTRO: Today we are going to be examining the ordinance of water baptism and why it is so very crucial for a Christian to take this very important step.

I. WATER BAPTISM IS AN ACT RESERVED FOR THOSE WHO HAVE ACCEPTED CHRIST AS THEIR SAVIOR

Water baptism is meaningless unless it is the act of one who has accepted the Lord Jesus Christ as their personal Savior. Once a person has decided to follow Christ the next step is water baptism.

Water baptism should occur as soon after conversion as possible. (Phillip and the Ethiopian Eunuch) Acts 8:36-38 (NKJV) ***“As they went down the road, they came to some water. And the eunuch said, “See, here is water. What hinders me from being baptized?””***³⁷***Then Philip said, “If you believe with all your heart, you may.” And he answered and said, “I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God.”***

³⁸So he commanded the chariot to stand still. And both Philip and the eunuch went down into the water, and he baptized him.

Water baptism should receive high priority!

Look at the instance of Paul and Silas converting the Philippian Jailer. Acts 16:30-33 (NKJV) ***“He (The jailer) brought them out and said, “Sirs, what must I do to be saved?” ³¹So they said, “Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and you will be saved, you and your household.” ³²Then they spoke the word of the Lord to him and to all who were in his house. ³³And he took them the same hour of the night and washed their stripes. And immediately he and all his family were baptized.”***

I strongly encourage you; if you have not been baptized in water, it is time to take the plunge today!

II. WATER BAPTISM IS AN ACT OF OBEDIENCE, NOT AN ACT OF REGENERATION

Mark 16:15-16 (NKJV) *“He said to them, “Go into all the world and preach the gospel to every creature. ¹⁶“He who believes and is baptized will be saved; but he who does not believe will be condemned.”*

Some passages sound as though baptism itself saves but we know from the example of the thief on the cross that one may be saved even though he has not had opportunity in life to be baptized. (The thief on the cross)

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III. WATER BAPTISM IS NOT OPTIONAL FOR OBEDIENT DISCIPLES

Water baptism signifies entrance into the visible Church, just as conversion secured entrance into the invisible Church.

Too many people view water baptism as insignificant or unimportant. Those who do so, place a very low priority on this very important step in the Christian life.

Even though water baptism does not save, one cannot get much further down the road as a disciple of Jesus until they submit to this ordinance. The reason the growth process of a Christian who has not been water baptized is stunted, is because they are walking in disobedience.

Because water baptism is a gateway into identification with the church Jesus died to build, obedience to this ordinance is not optional!

CONCLUSION:

The message being proclaimed in water baptism is:

- The old life has left me in a filthy condition...

- I no longer choose to be identified with the old life...
- By an act of my own will I am choosing for my old life to be buried in Jesus...
- I am going to be raised from the baptismal water a new person living a new lifestyle...
- It is an outward testimony of an inward work...

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